

SEALED SOLUTION

Stop here until you commit.

This file reveals the investigation, the identities, and the ending. Keep it separate from the player packet.

Before continuing, write your conclusion, cite the records that support it, and name an uncertainty the file does not resolve.

Read the evidence-cited solution first. The expanded aftermath follows the original ending. It develops the human consequences; it does not supply a clue needed to solve the case.

A blank reverse follows this cover so the first answer starts on a fresh sheet when this file is printed on both sides.

SPOILER BARRIER

The answer is overleaf.

Keep this file closed until your written reconstruction is complete.

The first heir is not a stranger

Irene Moss is first. Daniel Wren is second. Irene was born Anna Wren on 10 October 1891 to Daniel and Margaret. The daughter he believed dead survives under a name he did not know. Her priority comes through Margaret's elder royal branch, not through her father.

The notice is genuine within the case. K18 independently verifies dispatch V-228 and its signatory. K01 reports a provisional position and asks for records; it does not crown Daniel or make his agent a state official. K02 is a separate unsigned private declaration.

Helena to Margaret. K04 establishes Helena Arden -> Louise Arden/Vale -> Celia Vale. K05 connects Celia by exact birthday, birthplace and parent pair to her marriage with Thomas Hale in Elmsreach. K06 records their daughter Margaret and her marriage to Daniel. K10 records Margaret's daughter Anna.

Anna to Irene. K11 matches Anna's full birth date, parents and address and transfers the living child under E-214 to F-37. K14 preserves that reference and records the later name Irene Alder under A-77. K15 uses A-77 and the same birthday when Irene marries Samuel Moss. K16 verifies Irene Moss alive at the school in April 1928.

The emotional result is supported evidence. These links identify a living daughter of the widower and his deceased wife. Whether she wishes to meet him or accept a crown is not established by genealogy.

Why the younger person comes first

Daniel has his own real claim. K07 traces Otto Arden -> Frederick Arden -> Edmund Arden. K08 joins Edmund Arden to Edmund Wren by date, place and parents. K09 names Edmund as Daniel's father. Daniel does not inherit a bloodline simply by marrying Margaret.

Branch priority precedes age across branches. K03 places every qualifying Helena descendant before the Otto remainder. Irene belongs to Helena's line through her mother; Daniel belongs to Otto's line through his father. His greater age and closer generation do not move the younger branch ahead.

Adoption and sex do not defeat Irene. K03 expressly retains descent after adoption or a name change and gives no preference based on sex. K14 changes Anna's legal family name; it does not erase the birth-parent chain for this fictional Settlement. K18 confirms no relevant registered renunciation.

The royal ancestry belongs to two distant family branches. Daniel and Margaret share remote dynastic ancestry, not a parent or grandparent. The provided generations remain separate until their marriage. Do not merge similarly named people or transfer a spouse's place in the order.

Why this result is bounded. K18 stipulates that the reigning line has ended, that the intervening ancestors are dead, and that there is no other eligible living branch or unprovided amendment. Within those explicit bounds, the traced living child takes first place and Daniel takes second.

The notice, the pressure and the answer

The old death notice was wrongly applied. K12 gives only Anna and 214. K13 identifies the deceased as Anna Ward, W-214, born 3 January 1891 to James Ward and Helen Booth at another address. Anna Wren is E-214, born 10 October 1891 to Daniel and Margaret. K11 and K14 positively record the Wren child alive after the Ward death. The notice explains Daniel's belief; it does not prove his daughter died.

Do not sign declaration B. Its claim that no descendant of Margaret survives conflicts with the identity chain. Daniel should provide the evidence to the Legation directly and request correction/confirmation of the senior claim. He should not give the private office sole control of correspondence while that evidence is withheld.

What the private memorandum proves. K17 directs staff to secure the declaration before disclosing the Alder papers, conceal the living-child finding and omit contrary settlement text. It supports deliberate suppression by that office. It does not prove that the Legation, school or adoptive parents participated.

What remains uncertain. The packet does not identify who originally misaddressed the 1892 notice, whether that old error was deliberate, or why the birth parents were recorded as untraced in the later adoption application. Those questions are distinct from proving Irene's identity and present priority.

Daniel puts the unsigned declaration back in its envelope. On a clean sheet he writes: "Dear Irene. My name is Daniel Wren. I believe I am your father. If you wish it, I would very much like to meet you." He does not begin with Your Majesty.

The closing letter is narrative resolution, not a required clue or a prediction of Irene's response. The case ends with a supported identity, a corrected order and an invitation.

AFTER THE CASE

A letter without a title

After the original solution and ending

Daniel read his letter again before folding it. Dear Irene. He had written that name with more care than any of the titles supplied in the papers from Veyr.

The evidence placed Irene Moss, formerly Irene Alder and born Anna Wren, first through Margaret's senior branch. Daniel remained second through his own paternal line. Wanting to be a father did not determine the succession. Wanting him to be the convenient claimant did not erase a living descendant. Those were conclusions the records and settlement could support.

What Irene might say to him was another kind of question.

He could send the notice he had believed. He could explain his pencil beside it. He could provide the care and identity records so she could test what he claimed rather than trust an unknown man's longing. None of that entitled him to be welcomed.

He almost added that he and Margaret had suffered too. Then he left the sentence out. It was true that grief had shaped their lives. It was not Irene's first duty, on hearing his account, to comfort him for it.

He wrote that she could choose whether they met.

The words felt insufficient, and he let them remain insufficient. A promise to accept her choice would have to be kept later, when there was an actual choice to accept. Writing it could not complete that work in advance.

Beside the letter lay the papers for the legation. Orme's declaration was still unsigned. Daniel had separated what the case proved about the present suppression from what it did not prove about the old mistaken notice and the description of the birth parents as untraced. He would not make an accusation against everyone in an institution merely because one man's later conduct was demonstrably dishonest.

There was satisfaction in that restraint, but no escape from responsibility. His own annotation was still his. Checking now did not mean he had checked then.

He put the second cup back on the shelf that evening. He did not set it aside for Irene. She had a house, a profession, a husband, a life that was not waiting in Margaret's chair. If she came, he could ask what she wanted and take down another cup.

A reply might come. Until it did, Daniel would have to live with the question he was putting in another person's hands. He could supply the evidence, refuse the convenient falsehood, and ask for contact. Whether she wanted to call him Father was hers to decide.